City Weekly
BOSTON SUNDAY GLOBE SEPTEMBER 15, 2002

A new kind of urban gentry

► NEWCOMERS
Continued from Page 1

ROXBURY

Now, the gentrifiers are black

Out-of-towners add spark, and sparks, to old neighborhood

By Johnny Diaz
GLOBE STAFF

Ken Granderson passionately preaches about the power and perks of the personal computer for low-income communities from his cyber-evangelical pulpit: www.roxbury.com.

"It's important for folks who are on a progressive career path to stay in predominantly black communities, to help make sure that 'black community' doesn't stay synonymous with 'poor communities,' " says Brooklyn native Granderson, sitting in his 11-room 1915 Colonial house on the Roxbury-Dorchester divide, a few blocks from Franklin Park.

His house is also home to Inner City Software, where he and six other employees work on projects such as www.roxbury.com (an online community bulletin board with news of events and happenings in the area that launched earlier this year) and Boston Blacks Online, an online cafe with more than 4,000 members globally. As Granderson gazes around his conference room, which was a bedroom in a previous incarnation, he says, "There is no reason that middle-class folks have to stay outside of the city. I never understood why gentrification always had to be white folks from the suburbs moving into the city. Why can't it be black folks?"

Blacks such as Granderson represent a small dispersal of middle-class folks who are returning to or discovering such historic neighborhoods. Many transplant themselves here in search of a colorful past they saw — or wished they had seen — in their native communities as children.

Granderson hopes such tensions throughout Roxbury can be worked out and a balance found as older residents try to hang on to their homes while black professionals move into historic black pockets to try and rebuild them.

"If you come in with an individualistic mindset, you would have removed the area's soul," said Granderson.

In dreams about his utopian neighborhood, Granderson sees a consortium of black professionals buying up properties in historic black areas and collaborating with veteran residents so they could maintain their homes and revel in the area's urban renewal with the newcomers.

"I would hope that more black professionals would recognize the power that comes moving into neighborhoods where little kids see you and think, 'This person looks like me and is a stock broker or a doctor on my block,' " said Granderson, who is looking to launch dorchester.com and mattapan.com in projects he sees as "breaking the virtual ice."

"People emulate that which they look up to," he says. "If you remove your upper echelon of accomplishment from your area, who could blame kids for not emulating that" — and moving away themselves when they reach adulthood.